

Board 1

North Deals

None Vul

♠ K 10 9 8
♥ 9 6 3
♦ Q J 4
♣ 9 7 2

♠ Q J 7 4

♥ A K

♦ 10 8 6 2

♣ A K Q

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ 5 2

♥ Q J 10 8 4

♦ K 9

♣ J 8 6 3

♠ A 6 3

♥ 7 5 2

♦ A 7 5 3

♣ 10 5 4

West

North

East

South

Pass

1♦

Pass

2♦

3NT

All Pass

3NT by North

This is one of the most misplayed positions in bridge. The usual approach is to lead the ♠Q, hoping that East holds the ♠K. But this can't succeed. If East does hold the ♠K he will cover, either this trick or the ♠J, and someone's ♠10 will become a winner. Of course if West has the ♠K then the finesse will fail, along with your chance of 2 more winners.

The correct way to play for 2 more tricks is to hope **WEST** has the ♠K and lead twice toward your ♠Q J. So win the first trick, play ♠4 to dummy's ♠A. Lead the ♠3 toward your hand, playing the ♠J if West plays low. (Of course if West ever plays the ♠K he gives you two winners immediately.) When the ♠J wins, return to dummy with the ♦A and lead the ♠6 toward your ♠Q.

When West holds the ♠K you can always get 3 ♠ tricks if you play correctly.

With 19 points you are too strong to open 1NT so you open 1♦. Partner responds 2♦.

Perhaps you can make 5♦. But 9 tricks are easier than 11 so you bid 3NT. Notice that there was no reason to "show" your ♠ suit. If partner held 4 ♠s he would not have bid 2♦.

North plays 3NT. East leads the ♥Q.

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Winners: ♠ 1 : ♥ 2 : ♦ 1 : ♣ 3 : Total = 7

You can create one winner in ♦s if they split 3-2, but too late, the defense would have set up their ♥s. So you must get 2 more ♠ tricks.

Board 3

West Deals

E-W Vul

♠ 6 4
♥ A 7 3
♦ K Q 5 4
♣ A K 8 2

♠ K 5
♥ J 9 5 2
♦ A 8 6
♣ 9 7 6 3

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ Q J 9 8 7 3
♥ K Q 6
♦ 7 2
♣ J 4

♠ A 10 2
♥ 10 8 4
♦ J 10 9 3
♣ Q 10 5

<i>West</i>	<i>North</i>	<i>East</i>	<i>South</i>
1NT	Pass	4♠	
All Pass			

4♠ by East

South wins with an honor and probably plays the ♦ 10. Ruff it, lead a ♣ to dummy and lead the last ♠. If North plays the other high honor you play low. If North plays low you guess whether to play the ♠ K, or ♠ 10. Your best play is to assume the two honors were split and play the ♠ Q.

Leading twice toward the ♠ Q J gives you a guarantee on this layout because North held a doubleton high honor.

Now

Here South has taken your ♠ J with the ♠ A. When you again lead a small ♠ from dummy say that North plays the ♠ 5.

You might think that South is just as likely to have held an original doubleton ♠ A K as doubleton ♠ A 10, and that playing the ♠ 9 would be as good a play as ♠ Q.

This is untrue for a very classy-named reason - **The Principle of Restricted Choice**. You may not even believe it when you read it, but it's mathematically sound. If South were dealt an original ♠ A K, he would have been just as likely to win with the ♠ K as with the ♠ A. The fact that he actually won the ♠ A makes it less likely that he also holds the ♠ K.

HE WHO KNOWS, GOES You **KNOW** your side has 26-28 points. You **KNOW** your side has 8 or more ♠ s. You **GO** to 4♠.

East plays 4♠. South leads the ♦ J.

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Losers: ♠ 2/3 : ♥ 0 : ♦ 1 : ♣ 0 : Total = 3/4

You are definitely going to lose the ♦ A and the ♠ A K. Therefore you must plan to avoid losing a third ♠.

You should lead **UP TO** your honor cards. Cover the ♦ J and lose to North's ♦ A. Win his return (probably another ♦) in dummy. Lead a small ♠ to your ♠ J.